

FOOD & CATERING

The catering & event *food cheat sheet*

Every planning number behind CalcForged's food calculators on two pages — per-person quantities, BBQ yields, taco-bar math, and wedding budget ranges. Estimates, not gospel: adjust for your menu, your guests, and your event.

01 How much food per person (full meal)

CATEGORY	PLANNING RULE	SHARE OF TOTAL	50 GUESTS
Total food	1–1.5 lb per adult (plan 1.25 lb)	—	≈ 62.5 lb
Protein	Mains, meat, fish	35%	≈ 21.9 lb
Sides	Starches, vegetables	35%	≈ 21.9 lb
Salads	Greens, cold salads	15%	≈ 9.4 lb
Dessert	Cake, sweets, fruit	10%	≈ 6.3 lb
Beverages	2 servings per guest	—	100 servings

MEAL FORMAT

Full meal ×1.25 lb/guest · **Light meal** ×1.0 · **Heavy appetizers** ×0.75. Buffet service, big appetites, or events over 3 hours: add 5–10%.

02 BBQ meat: buy by yield, not by serving

MEAT	RAW → COOKED YIELD	BUY FOR 30 GUESTS (6 OZ EACH)
Brisket	≈ 50%	≈ 22.5 lb raw
Pulled pork	≈ 57%	≈ 19.7 lb raw
Ribs	≈ 52% (bones)	≈ 21.6 lb raw
Chicken	≈ 67%	≈ 16.7 lb raw
Sausage	≈ 80%	≈ 13.6 lb raw

THE FORMULA

Raw lb = guests × cooked oz ÷ 16 ÷ yield. Baseline 6 oz cooked per guest; 8 oz for meat-only menus. Yield covers trimming, moisture loss, and bones.

03 Taco bar math

ITEM	PLANNING RULE	25 ADULTS + 10 KIDS
Tacos	2 per adult · 1 per child	60 tacos
Cooked meat	2–4 oz per taco (plan 3 oz)	≈ 11.3 lb
Tortillas	+20% cushion for breakage	≈ 72
Toppings	3 servings per guest	105 servings
Sides	0.75 servings per guest	27 servings

04 Wedding catering budget ranges (per guest)

MEAL STYLE	FOOD & SERVICE	WITH DRINKS
Plated dinner	\$75–\$150	Full bar ×1.25 · Beer & wine ×1.0 · None ×0.85
Buffet	\$55–\$110	Dessert: 1 serving per guest, +25% if serving cake <i>and</i> a dessert table.
Cocktail-only	\$45–\$95	

WORKED EXAMPLE

100-guest buffet wedding with beer, wine, and cake ≈ **\$5,500–\$11,000** catering range. Real quotes swing on staffing, rentals, tax, and gratuity — ask caterers what's excluded.

05 Five rules that save events

Plan in pounds, order with a buffer. Estimates are starting points — add 5–10% for buffets, big appetites, or long events.

Meat is a yield problem. The weight on the smoker is never the weight on the plate. Brisket loses half its raw weight.

Drinks run 2 servings per guest — more for hot days, long programs, or heavy bar service.

Dessert for every guest. One serving each, plus a quarter more if cake and dessert table both appear.

Write the shopping list from the calculator, then price it. Numbers beat memory when the guest count changes.

RUN THE NUMBERS

Free calculators at [calcforged.com](https://www.calcforged.com) — Catering Food Quantity · BBQ Meat · Taco Bar · Wedding Food · plus 20 more for the kitchen, the house, and the job site.